When the two sides did finally clash, neither was expecting it. On 2 November 1840, Sale and Burnes had cleverly been drawn by the Amir across the Panjshir and away from their base at Charikar. They were moving up the wooded valley Parwan Darra, with its lines of mud-walled forts and rich apricot orchards, heading on to attack a distant rebel fortress, when intelligence came that Dost Mohammad was just ahead and riding fast towards them. Within minutes, the Amir and his 400 cavalry had appeared in view on an elevated piece of ground just ahead of the British. Sale's guns were at the rear, so, without waiting for them to be brought up, those at the head of the column, including Burnes's close friend Dr Percival Lord – known to the Afghan poets as 'Daaktar' – decided to lead the attack. The British officers spurred their horses into a charge, only to realise too late that their own Indian cavalry squadrons had turned and fled. What followed was for the Afghan poets a supreme moment of triumph for Dost Mohammad.

Then the *Daaktar* leapt up like smoke
With all the war-like cavalry that was with him

The Amir eyed up the *Daaktar*
That wretched dog

And he leapt on his horse
With all speed, as fast as fire

Down from the granite hills
Went he, his cavalry following behind

Drawing the sword of rancour from its sheath
They leapt forward without delay

They pounced on the Christians,
The field grew warm with Firangi blood

The clamour of the brave rose up to the heavens
Dust filled the eyes of the Sun and of Jupiter

Soon the earth was 'stained rose-red with heroes' blood'.

The heroes slaughtered the men of Firang
That day of war was like as to the apocalypse